

ST 01: Introduction to Theology

Teaching Notes, Part 3: Unit II — The Nature of Theology (Lectures 6 to 10)

Morning Star Regional Seminary, Barrackpore For the use of the Professor

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These are your notes. Each lecture gives the opening problem, the teaching content, the references, the cross-references to the rest of the course, the illustrations for the board, and a teaching tip with the reading and the reflection prompt.

THE ARC OF UNIT II

Unit II answers the first of the six goals, what is theology, and it does so in five steps that build on one another. Lecture 6 shows that theology is reflection on the event of Christ and not the event itself, so that experience comes first and theology second. Lecture 7 shows that the very word theology has carried different meanings across the ages, from the pagan poets to the praying Fathers to the schoolmen. Lecture 8 follows the word into the modern and the contemporary periods and arrives at the working definition the students will carry for life. Lecture 9 asks whether theology is a science, and answers that it is a science and also a wisdom and a prayer. Lecture 10 draws the line between authentic theology and its corruption, heresy, and so it sharpens the definition by showing what theology is not. Two of the seven polarities of theology, mystery with intelligibility and commitment with searching, find their home in Lecture 9, and the others are seeded across the unit.

LECTURE 6: Why did Jesus never write a theology book?

The opening problem. Put the question and let it sit. Jesus is the Word of God made flesh, the wisest teacher who ever lived, and yet he wrote no book, left no treatise, composed no system. Why not? If theology matters so much, why did its very centre leave nothing in writing? The answer opens the whole nature of theology: Jesus did not write theology because he did not do theology, he was its subject. He was the event, the revelation in person. Theology is what the community does afterward, in reflecting on him.

The teaching content. Theology is second-order. It is reflection on the Christ-event, not the event itself. First the disciples lived with Jesus, walked with him, watched him die, met him risen; that is the first-order experience. Only after the resurrection and the gift of the Spirit did they reflect on what they had seen and put it into words, and that reflection is the New Testament, which is rightly called the first and normative theology, the earliest interpretation of the mystery. So the order is fixed and must never be reversed: experience first, then reflection, and finally commitment. Faith experience is the starting point of all

theologising, and theology is, in the end, the putting into words of an experience of God, using ordinary language in an extraordinary way.

This teaches the students a lesson they will need all their lives: a theology cut off from the living experience of faith goes dry, like a riverbed with no spring above it. It also explains a fact that often unsettles beginners, that even within the New Testament there is not one theology but many. The single Christ-event gave rise to many readings, Logos Christology in John, Messianic Christology in the Synoptics and Acts, cosmic Christology in Colossians, the high-priestly Christology of Hebrews. This is not confusion; it is the natural fruit of a community reflecting from many angles on one inexhaustible mystery, and it prepares the students for the plurality of theologies they will meet later.

Illustration. The grandmother and the recipe. A grandmother cooks a feast that the whole family remembers for years; the feast is the event. Only later does someone watch her, write down the recipe, and pass it on so that others may share the taste; the recipe is the theology. You cannot have the recipe without the cooking first, and a recipe that has never been cooked feeds no one. Jesus cooked the feast of salvation; the apostles wrote down the recipe so the Church could taste it in every age. A second image: the love letter. Lovers first fall in love, and only afterward do they write letters trying to put into words what they have already lived. The New Testament is the love letter of the early Church, written after the encounter with the risen Lord, never before it.

References. Luke 24:13 to 35, for the pattern of experience before articulation, the burning hearts before the recognition. *Dei Verbum* 4, for Christ as the mediator and fullness of revelation. Karl Rahner, for the self-communication of God in history which we call Christ. Raymond Brown, "Christology," in the New Jerome Biblical Commentary, and Roger Haight, *Jesus Symbol of God*, for the plurality of New Testament Christologies.

Cross-references. This lecture opens the first goal and grounds the order of experience, reflection, and commitment that governs the contextual method of Unit V, Lectures 23 to 27. The plurality of New Testament Christologies prepares Lecture 8, on theology that begins from experience, and Lecture 11, on why there are many theologians. Experience as a source of theology returns in Lecture 15.

For the professor. Use this lecture to answer the worry of the pious student from Lecture 2 in a new way. Theology never replaces the experience of faith; it serves it, the way the recipe serves the feast. End by asking the class to name the experience that first made God real for them, since that experience is where their own theology will begin. Reading: Ormerod, Chapter 1, pages 10 to 14, and a short section of Müller, *What is Theology?* Reflection prompt: "If theology is reflection on Christ rather than Christ himself, then..."

LECTURE 7: Has theology always meant the same thing? (Part one)

The opening problem. Ask the class whether the word theology meant the same thing to Paul, to Augustine, and to Aquinas. They will assume it did. It did not. Then hand them a small shock that the library hunt has prepared: the word *theologia* is older than

Christianity. The pagan Greeks used it first. The meaning of theology has a history, and so the question what is theology cannot be answered by one fixed definition.

The teaching content. Trace the word through three early senses. First, the pre-Christian origin. Plato, in the second book of the *Republic*, seems to coin the word *theologia* for the right way to speak of the gods in poetry. Aristotle uses the related term for first philosophy, the study of the divine and unmoved cause, what we would call metaphysics. So the word was borrowed from the pagans and then baptised, which is itself a lesson in how the Gospel takes up and purifies the goods of every culture.

Second, the patristic sense, which is loftier and narrower than ours. For the Greek Fathers, *theologia* meant the contemplation and inspired knowledge of God himself, above all of the Holy Trinity, and they distinguished it from *oikonomia*, the study of the works of God in the history of salvation. In this sense theology was not first an academic exercise but a fruit of prayer. Evagrius of Pontus gave the lasting formula: the one who prays truly is a theologian, and the theologian is the one who prays truly. Here theology is contemplative, doxological, born on the knees.

Third, the scholastic sense, which is closest to ours. In the medieval schools *theologia* came to mean the orderly, reasoned study of the doctrines of the Christian faith, theology as a science pursued in the classroom. Thomas Aquinas treated sacred doctrine as a true science, though a unique one. Each of these three senses is true and each stresses something the others can forget: the biblical and inspired reflection, the contemplative knowledge of God, the systematic science. A full account of theology holds all three.

Illustration. A word that shifts its weight across the generations. Take the Indian word *guru*. Once it named a spiritual master who removed the darkness of ignorance; today it is used for any expert, a fitness guru or a market guru. The word survives, but its weight has shifted. Theology has made the same journey, from the gods of the pagan poets, to the inspired writers, to the praying Fathers, to the arguing schoolmen. A second image: a family house added to across the generations. One generation lays the biblical foundation, another builds the patristic chapel of prayer, another adds the scholastic lecture hall. A theologian lives in the whole house and not in one room only.

References. Plato, *Republic*, Book II, for the early use of *theologia*. Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, Book VI, for theology as first philosophy. Catechism of the Catholic Church 236, for the distinction between *theologia* and *oikonomia* in the Fathers. Evagrius of Pontus, *On Prayer*, 60, for theology as the fruit of prayer. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* Ia, q. 1, for the scholastic sense of theology as science. The Manual, pages 1 to 2 and 5 to 7, for the patristic and scholastic senses.

Cross-references. The contemplative patristic sense returns in Lecture 29, on Orthodox theology, theology on the knees, and the library hunt for the earliest use of *theologia* pays off here. The scholastic sense is taken up fully in Lecture 19, the Scholastic age. The way the Gospel baptised a pagan word prepares the discussion of inculturation in Lecture 27.

For the professor. Let this lecture teach humility about ownership. No single age owns the word theology, and the contemplative sense of the Fathers is not a relic but a permanent

correction to any theology that becomes all head and no knees. Reading: the Manual, pages 1 to 2 and 5 to 7, and a short section of Müller. Reflection prompt: "The meaning of theology that surprises me most is..."

LECTURE 8: Has theology always meant the same thing? (Part two)

The opening problem. Continue the story of the word into the modern and the contemporary periods, and name the great shift that happened there. Classical theology tended to begin at the top, with the revealed truths, and to reason downward to their application. Much contemporary theology begins at the bottom, with human experience, suffering, and context, and reflects upward toward the mystery. Ask the students which is the right place to begin, and then show that the question itself is the heart of contemporary theology.

The teaching content. In the modern period theology recovered the riches of Scripture, liturgy, and Tradition, and it took what is called the turn to the subject. Karl Rahner taught that the proper object of theology is not God considered in the abstract but the human person as related to God, so that theology becomes in large part a theological anthropology. In the contemporary period a second turn followed, the turn to context and to praxis. Gustavo Gutiérrez defined theology as critical reflection on Christian praxis in the light of the Word, and from this root grew the many definitions of theology as faith seeking not only understanding but justice, dialogue, love, interiority, harmony, integrity, and ritual expression, each generating its own kind of theology. Michael Amaladoss described theology as the believing search for an experiential understanding of God that transforms life, and Roger Haight described it as the understanding of all reality through the central symbols of the faith. Neil Ormerod sets the two ages side by side: where the older theology treated theology as a deposit of fixed truths to be handed down, the newer treats it as a mediation, a living conversation between the faith of the Church and the culture and experience of the people.

Now give the students the working definition and have them write it in the glossary, for it is one of the central deliverables of the course. Christian theology is the orderly and searching interpretation of the meaning of human life and of reality as a whole, from the standpoint of the revelation given in Jesus Christ, joined to the continual reinterpretation of Christian faith in the light of the new experience and the changing situation of the world, carried out in and by the believing community. Unpack it phrase by phrase. Orderly and searching means it is at once systematic and self-examining. Interpretation of meaning means it is hermeneutical. Of human life and of all reality means it embraces the human, the cosmic, and the divine together. From the standpoint of the revelation in Jesus Christ means it is Christocentric. Reinterpretation in the light of new experience means it is contextual and never finished. In and by the believing community means the community itself is the place where theology is done, the *locus theologicus*.

Illustration. The mountain climbed from two sides. Classical theology is like coming down from the summit, where the revealed truth shines, and mapping the slopes on the way

down. Contemporary theology is like climbing up from the valley, from the place where the people live and suffer, toward the summit. Both reach the one mountain, but the starting point changes what you notice on the way. A second image: the river. Classical theology follows the water from the source down to the plains; liberation and contextual theology begin in the flooded plain, among the people whose fields are under water, and trace the flood back to ask what the source requires of us. Neither forgets the source; they begin at different ends of the same river.

References. Neil Ormerod, *Introducing Contemporary Theologies*, Chapter 3, for the contrast of contemporary and previous theology. Gustavo Gutiérrez, *A Theology of Liberation*, for theology as critical reflection on praxis. Karl Rahner, for the turn to the subject and theological anthropology. Michael Amaladoss, "Towards an Indian Theology," and Roger Haight, *Dynamics of Theology*, for their definitions. The working definition follows the formulation in the standard *Introduction to Theology*, pages 20 to 21. *Gaudium et Spes* 4, for theology as the reading of the signs of the times in the light of the Gospel.

Cross-references. The working definition is the backbone the students carry into every later unit. The turn to context and praxis opens Unit V, the methods, Lectures 23 to 29, and grounds the Indian context of Lectures 26 and 27. The definition of theology as faith seeking justice returns in Lecture 15 and Lecture 26.

For the professor. Spend real time on the working definition, because it serves two of the six goals at once, the first by saying what theology is, and the third by hinting how it is done. Have each student copy it into the glossary and be ready to unpack any one phrase on demand. A definition that can be unpacked is owned; one that is only memorised is soon lost. Reading: Ormerod, Chapter 3, pages 27 to 37. Reflection prompt: "Starting theology from experience rather than doctrine makes me think of..."

LECTURE 9: Is theology a science?

The opening problem. Ask it bluntly. Is theology a science, like physics or chemistry, with real knowledge, or is it only opinion, or piety, or the comparing of religions? This is the day of the unit debate, and the motion is, is theology a science or a life? Let both sides argue, then bring them to the resolution that refuses the false choice: theology is a science, and it is also a wisdom, and it is also a prayer.

The teaching content. Theology is a science in a real sense. It has a proper subject, God and all things in their relation to God; it has a proper method, the orderly use of reason upon what God has revealed; and it produces ordered, examinable knowledge that can be taught, argued, and corrected. Thomas Aquinas defends theology as a science, but a unique one. The natural sciences prove their own first principles or read them from the world; theology receives its first principles by faith, from the self-knowledge of God revealed to us, and reasons from there. So theology is a science whose foundations are held in faith, which is why it can never be merely one science among the others. It differs from the natural sciences in this: they know by human reason unaided, while theology knows by faith in

divine revelation. The sciences answer many questions of how; theology addresses the deeper questions of why, the limit-questions of meaning that no microscope can reach. The two are partners, not rivals.

But theology is more than a science. Aquinas calls it a wisdom, because it judges all things in the light of the highest cause, God himself, and wisdom orders and unifies what mere knowledge leaves scattered. And theology is more than a wisdom; it is a committed engagement that changes the one who does it, a discipline done on the knees. Here you teach the first two of the seven polarities that a theologian must hold. The first is mystery and intelligibility: theology must be intelligible, a real reasoning, and yet it must always guard the mystery of God, so that it never explains God away. The second is committed and searching: theology is a committed engagement that challenges and changes our lives, and at the same time a searching activity that examines all beliefs and practices in the light of present knowledge and experience. Lose the first balance and theology becomes either superstition or rationalism; lose the second and it becomes either fanaticism or cold detachment.

Illustration. Swimming. You can study the science of swimming from a book on the shore, the buoyancy, the mechanics of the stroke, and all of it is true and useful. But you only truly know swimming when you are in the water. A theologian who only reads about God and never prays is like a man who has memorised the swimming manual and then drowns in the village pond. Theology is the manual studied and the river entered. A second image, from the Psalms: salt. You can analyse salt in a laboratory and write its formula, and that is real knowledge; but you only know salt when you taste it. "O taste and see that the Lord is good," says Psalm 34. Theology analyses and theology tastes, and the one who only analyses has never met the Lord he describes.

References. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* Ia, q. 1, articles 2 to 6, for theology as a science and as wisdom and for its subalternation to the knowledge of God. The Manual, on theology and the natural sciences, for the many answered hows and the unanswered whys. Neil Ormerod, *Introducing Contemporary Theologies*, Chapter 4, on method. Psalm 34:8, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition, for taste and see.

Cross-references. Theology as wisdom and as prayer reaches back to the patristic sense of Lecture 7 and forward to Orthodox theology in Lecture 29. The question of theology as a science connects to the place of philosophy in Lecture 11 and to the branches of theology in Lecture 24. The remaining five polarities appear across the course, identity and change in Unit IV, the one and the many and the universal and the contextual in Unit V, orthodoxy and orthopraxis in the praxis model of Lecture 26.

For the professor. Run this as a true debate, since it is the participation exercise of the week, and then bring the class firmly to both and. The danger you are guarding against is real and runs both ways: the seminarian who makes theology all head, a dry science with no prayer, and the seminarian who makes it all heart, a warm piety with no rigour. This house means to form men who are both. Reading: Ormerod, Chapter 4, pages 42 to 52. Reflection prompt: "Theology is a science and also more than a science because..."

LECTURE 10: What makes theology true, and not heresy?

The opening problem. If theology is searching, plural, and always open, the sharp student will ask whether it has any limit at all. Can theology say anything it likes? When does it go wrong? Pose the question honestly, because a course that has stressed openness must now show that openness has banks. There is a line, and on the far side of it lies heresy, which is the corruption of theology, not its freedom.

The teaching content. Begin with the marks of authentic theology, the six the seminary manual gives. Authentic theology is biblical, born from Scripture, living with it, and ending in it. It is Trinitarian, giving glory to the triune God as the purpose of all theologising. It is ecclesial, building up the Church. It is liturgical, born in the heart of the worshipping community. It is patristic, grounded in the Fathers who laid the foundations. And it is ecumenical, serving the prayer of Jesus that there be one flock and one shepherd. A theology that keeps these marks stays true; a theology that loses them drifts.

Then teach the line itself. The word heresy comes from the Greek *hairesis*, which means a choosing, the taking of a part against the whole. This is the inner shape of every heresy: it seizes one true thing and makes it the whole, rejecting the rest. Arius took the oneness of God and denied the divinity of the Son. Docetism took the divinity of Christ and denied his true humanity. Pelagius took human freedom and denied the priority of grace. In each case a single truth, torn from the others, became a falsehood that wounded the faith and the faithful. The great councils drew the lines in answer, Nicaea against Arius, Constantinople against those who denied the Spirit, Ephesus against Nestorius, Chalcedon against the Monophysites, and you will teach these fully in Lecture 18. It is the believing community, in continuity with Tradition and guided by the Magisterium, that discerns the line, not the lone theologian, a point that prepares the question of authority in Unit III.

Teach the line as an act of love. The Church does not draw it from fear of thought but to protect the truth and the people, because a false Christ gives a false hope, and a wounded faith wounds souls. And here you must be careful and honest, more careful than the old manuals. The ecumenical mark, the sixth, forbids us to fling the word heretic at fellow Christians or at other communions out of mere difference. The hard and necessary skill is to tell true heresy, a real corruption of the faith, apart from the legitimate variety of schools and the separated Christian communities with whom we share baptism and much of the faith. To confuse difference with heresy is itself a failure of charity and of the ecumenical mark.

Illustration. The riverbanks. A river needs banks, or it becomes either a destroying flood or a stagnant swamp. The marks of authentic theology are the banks that let the river of theology run with power toward the sea, which is the Kingdom. Banks do not stop the river; they give it direction and force, and heresy is the flood that has burst them. A second image, drawn from the very word: the single food. A man who insists on eating only rice and refuses every other food will starve, for all the goodness of rice. Heresy is choosing one good thing, the divinity of Christ, or his humanity, or grace, or freedom, and making it the

whole meal, until the soul starves on a single truth swallowed alone. The truth is the whole balanced meal.

References. The Manual, page 2, for the six marks, page 4, for the characteristics, and page 6, for theology against heresy, with 2 Peter 3:16 and Jude 17 to 19. The Greek *hairesis*, a choosing, for the inner shape of heresy. The councils of Nicaea, 325, Constantinople, 381, Ephesus, 431, and Chalcedon, 451, cross-referenced to Lecture 18. *Unitatis Redintegratio*, the Decree on Ecumenism, especially on legitimate diversity and the bond of baptism among separated Christians, for the right use of the ecumenical mark.

Cross-references. The marks of authentic theology become a criterion the students will use through the rest of the course. The heresies and the councils are taught fully in Lecture 18, the Patristic age. The discernment of the line by the community and the Magisterium is the matter of Lecture 14. The ecumenical mark connects to Orthodox theology in Lecture 29, to interreligious dialogue in Lecture 33, and to the closing word on ecumenism.

For the professor. Close the unit on the right note. Unit II has asked what theology is; this lecture completes the answer by showing what theology is not. Teach the line as protection and love, never as a hunt for enemies, and model for the students the balanced judgment that can hold both fidelity and charity, both the truth and the brother who sees it differently. That balance is itself a chief fruit you want the course to produce. Reading: the Manual, page 2, page 4, and page 6. Reflection prompt: "The mark of authentic theology I most need to guard is..."

CLOSING THE UNIT, AND THE BRIDGE TO UNIT III

By the end of Unit II the students should be able to say what theology is in several true ways at once: that it is reflection on the event of Christ and not the event itself, that the word has carried different senses across the ages, that it is the orderly and searching interpretation of all reality from the standpoint of the revelation in Christ and in and by the community, that it is a science and also a wisdom and a prayer, and that it has marks that keep it true and a corruption, heresy, that it must avoid. They have begun to own the working definition and the marks, and they have met two of the seven polarities. The natural next question is where theology gets its content and who has the authority to say what is true, and that is the work of Unit III, the sources of theology, which the next installment of these notes will cover, Lectures 11 to 16. There the first precept of Lonergan, be attentive, begins to govern, for the sources can be received only by a theologian who has first learned to attend.

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